

▶ STARTING AND FINISHING

Securing the thread at the beginning and end of any stitching is, of course, essential. Traditional hand sewing begins and ends with a knot at the end of the thread, but knots can interfere with quilting and sometimes

show on the top of the quilt. There are several knots that are useful for quiltmaking. Backstitched loops (see p.40) lie almost flat and are a secure way of finishing off a seam.

THREADING A NEEDLE



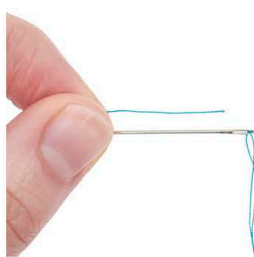
1 Trim the end of the thread. Insert the end of the thread through the eye of the needle, then cut to the desired length from the spool. Because of the way thread is twisted as it is made, threading the needle with the end that comes off the spool first will help prevent tangles.

2 After threading, run the thread between your thumb and forefinger in the direction that the thread came off the spool to smooth it.

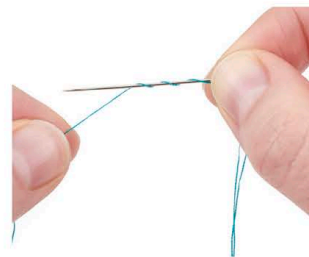
TIPS

- **Thread weight:** Use a thread weight that is appropriate to the size of the needle and a needle size that is suited to the weight of the fabric.
- **Thread length:** Keep the thread length to no more than 50cm (20in) long; it will be less likely to kink and fray.
- **Needle threader:** Use a needle threader if you have difficulty getting the thread through the eye.
- **Cutting direction:** Always cut away from your body when possible.
- **Knot size:** Knots make lumps wherever they occur, so make sure that knots are as small as possible so that they can be hidden easily.

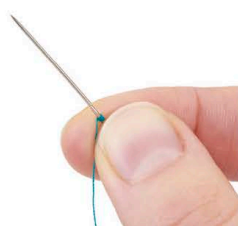
WRAPPED KNOT



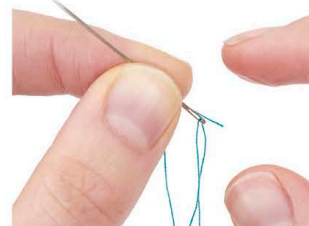
1 Thread the needle, then hold one free end of the thread parallel with the needle, as shown.



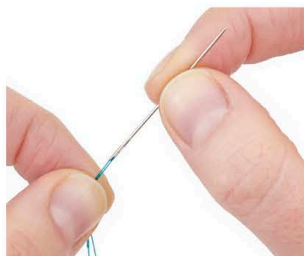
2 Take hold of the free end of the thread securely and wrap it around the needle a few times.



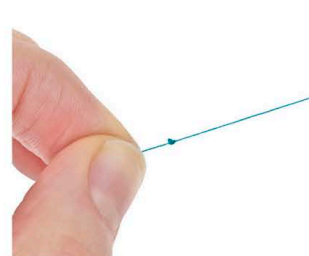
3 Slide the wraps towards the eye of the needle and hold them with your thumb and forefinger.



4 Grab the wraps between your index finger and thumb of the opposite hand.



5 Slide the wraps down the end of the needle, over the eye and down the thread.



6 Keep pulling the knot down the thread until it reaches near the bottom of the length of thread.